



Managing project sustainability in the extractive industries: Towards a reciprocity framework for community engagement

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ABSTRACT

Merely a peripheral discussion in project management up until recent years, sustainability has become a central issue in both academia and practice. Despite growing interest and research on sustainable project management, we still know little about how projects in the extractive industries, known for their significant local impact, can be used to foster inclusive sustainable development for local communities. Arguing that extractive industries have inadequately addressed the increasing demands of stakeholders for contributing to sustainable development, we build on the philosophical theory of capabilities and the principle of reciprocity to propose a new framework for community engagement and sustainable project management. The reciprocity framework for community engagement is based on the premise that a sustainable extractive project requires its promoter to nurture constructive and mutually beneficial relationships with local communities. By integrating moral considerations into our framework, we contribute to the paradigm shift required to embed projects in sustainable development by better balancing stakeholders' needs at the economic, environmental, and social levels.

1. Introduction

Sustainability is becoming a central dimension in the field of project management, increasing in importance in recent years (Kivilä, Martin-suo, & Vuorinen, 2017; Yuan, 2017). According to Sabini, Muzio, & Alderman, 2019 (p. 821), 73% of academic articles at the intersection of sustainability and project management were published between 2015 and 2019, which highlights the recency of this discussion. Both conceptual and empirical research has flourished that examines individual (Hwang & Ng, 2013; Martens & Carvalho, 2017; Silvius & Graaf, 2019), organizational (Banihashemi, Hosseini, Golizadeh, & Sankaran, 2017; Corbett, Webster, & Jenkin, 2018; Silvius, Kamping, Paniagua, & Mooi, 2017) and contextual dimensions (Hwang, Zhu, & Tan, 2017; Labuschagne & Brent, 2005) of sustainable development in project management. Several literature reviews also point to the importance of this trend due to its positive impacts on the practice of project management (Aarseth, Ahola, Aaltonen, Økland, & Andersen, 2017; Goel, Ganesh, & Kaur, 2019; Sabini, Muzio, & Alderman, 2019; Silvius & Schipper, 2014). Sustainability has even been presented as a new school of

thought in project studies (Silvius, 2017).

While the literature has analyzed sustainable project management in various empirical settings (construction, technology, services, and manufacturing, to name a few), there has been a particular focus on large infrastructure (Banihashemi, Hosseini, Golizadeh, & Sankaran, 2017) or natural resource development projects that generate significant local impacts (Cesar, 2019; Gómez-Valenzuela, Alpizar, Bonilla, & Franco-Billini, 2020; Holley & Mitcham, 2016). Such projects, especially those with considerable environmental impacts, are frequently met with controversy that challenges the legitimacy of the project (i.e., its social approval by key constituencies). These controversies can generate delays and additional costs (Demajorovic, Lopes, & Santiago, 2019) in obtaining a social license to operate, defined as a “community’s acceptance or approval of a specific company project or of the entire company’s ongoing operations in the community” (Cui, Jo, & Velasquez, 2016, p. 775).

This conceptual paper focuses on the specific case of the extractive industries, a context where “failure to adequately live up to societal expectations is now considered a significant threat to the viability of the

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industry” (Böhling, Murguía, & Godfrid, 2019, p. 191). It enriches our understanding of how projects with significant impact on local communities can meet stakeholder needs for sustainable development. In line with the substantial literature on extractive industries (Frederiksen, 2019; Schrecker, Birn, & Aguilera, 2018; Vijge, Metcalfe, Wallbott, & Oberlack, 2019), the concept of extractive projects used in this paper refers to development projects that aim to physically extract natural resources for commercialization purposes. Activities that are commonly a part of extractive projects include the exploration, exploitation, and expansion of mining sites that generate economic, social, cultural, and environmental impacts (Ranängen & Zobel, 2014; Veltmeyer & Bowles, 2014).

Three main reasons explain why extractive industries are a worthwhile context for developing theory about how projects can contribute to sustainable development in local communities. First, extractive industries affect the lives of billions of people around the world through the vital role they play in global economic development. Approximately 3.5 billion people live in countries rich in various extractive resources such as oil, gas, or minerals (World Bank, 2018). According to the World Bank, natural resources account for approximately a quarter of global GDP. Second, despite having great potential for bettering society, the extractive industries have frequently exhibited poor environmental and social performance, generating highly visible controversies that cause significant reputational damage (Dougherty & Olsen, 2014; Erdiaw-Kwasie, Alam, & Shahiduzzaman, 2017; Humby, 2016; Vijge, Metcalfe, Wallbott, & Oberlack, 2019). This includes environmental and social controversies, such as ecological negligence, corruption, and the unequal sharing of wealth and benefits with local communities (Brueckner, Durey, Pforr, & Mayes, 2014; Humby, 2016; Ranängen & Zobel, 2014). According to The Environmental Justice Atlas (2016 cited in Maher, 2019, p. 1047), there are over 700 mining-related conflicts around the world. Third, the complicity of the extractive industries in major and long-lasting controversies in the past several decades has resulted in firms having to contend with presumed beliefs about their industry that *a priori* threaten the legitimacy of any project (Lyytimäki & Peltonen, 2016). The extractive sector is clearly under heavy scrutiny, which allows it to serve as a particularly relevant context for studying project sustainability.

These challenges highlight the critical importance of community engagement for firms planning projects in this industry (Alves, Ferreira, & Araújo, 2020; Costanza, 2016; Melé & Armengou, 2016). Community engagement is defined as “the pattern of activities implemented by firms to work collaboratively with and through groups of people to address issues affecting the social well-being of those people” (Bowen, Newenham-Kahindi, & Herremans, 2010, p. 297). Within the project management literature (Cuganesan & Floris, 2020; van den Ende & van Marrewijk, 2019) and beyond (Bowen, Newenham-Kahindi, & Herremans, 2010; Delannon, Raufflet, & Baba, 2016; Maher, 2019), a substantial body of research has developed around the antecedents, processes, and outcomes of community engagement. Yet, as evidenced by social and environmental controversies and heavy scrutiny facing firms, projects are often considered failures in the eyes of local stakeholders who increasingly demand that they contribute to sustainable development (Alves, Ferreira, & Araújo, 2020; Baba, Raufflet, Murdoch, & Courcelles, 2016; Derakhshan, 2020; van den Ende & van Marrewijk, 2019).

Extant research has provided inadequate guidance for conducting extractive projects that promote sustainability in local communities due to being overly firm-centric and at times overly instrumental (i.e., economic profitability remains the central basis for decision-making) (Alves, Ferreira, & Araújo, 2020; Delannon, Raufflet, & Baba, 2016; Frederiksen, 2019). In light of common criticisms lodged against the extractive industries and limitations of the extant project management research, we pose the following research question: *how should community engagement strategies be designed in the extractive industries to ensure that projects meet stakeholder needs that are relevant to sustainable development?*

To address the theoretical shortcomings in the literature, we build on a normative, philosophical perspective called the capability approach, combined with the principle of reciprocity, to develop a framework of community engagement, which we label the reciprocity framework. This framework is centered on fostering local development to compensate for the extraction of natural resources. It is normative in the sense of being prescriptive rather than descriptive: it endorses claims that prescribe the sorts of actions that extractive firms should take, rather than claims that try to describe the sorts of actions that extractive firms do take. The importance of adequately compensating communities for extracting their natural resources is captured in the moral principle of reciprocity: when one party benefits from relating or interacting with another party, it is at least a good thing, and perhaps a moral obligation, for the benefitting party to return some of that benefit to the other party (Schmidt, 2006).

Key to our framework is the premise that a sustainable extractive project requires its promoter to nurture constructive and mutually beneficial relationships with local communities. Such relationships require that project promoters take into consideration the needs of local stakeholders, which, if done meaningfully, requires community engagement to be fashioned as an on-going process that accounts for how the needs of a community can evolve and change over both time and the course of a project (Eslerod & Ang, 2017; Eslerod & Huemann, 2013; Perrini & Tencati, 2006). We rely on the ‘capability approach’ from philosophical ethics to achieve a better theoretical understanding of the needs of local community members that are most relevant to sustainable project management. According to the capability approach, what is of primary importance for moral evaluation of sustainable development projects are the needs that are constitutive of stakeholders’ freedom to achieve well-being (Robeyns, 2016). An individual enjoys freedom to achieve well-being to the extent to which she enjoys the real opportunity to act based on, and become, what she has reason to value (Robeyns, 2016). The capability approach serves as a broader and more nuanced alternative to narrower economic conceptions of well-being, such as per capita gross domestic product, and has already been deployed in human development contexts, most notably by the United Nations Development Program (Frediani, 2010). These changes in how we approach sustainability in the context of extractive projects would allow project managers to meet rising expectations that projects fulfill not only traditional roles of project management, but also that projects are managed efficiently and effectively with respect to sustainability (Hwanga & Ng, 2013).

Our paper extends and challenges our understanding of sustainability in project studies in three ways. First, we integrate moral considerations in our framework. The relevance of moral and philosophical principles to business and management has been widely acknowledged since the development of normative stakeholder theory (Donaldson & Preston, 1995; Freeman, 1984). However, this moral perspective is not yet central to theory at the intersection of project management and sustainability, despite some implicit and explicit calls for considering the ‘moral imperative’ (Cicmil & Hodgson, 2006; Silvius, Schipper, & Nedeski, 2013) beyond business as usual. By integrating moral considerations into project management theory, we contribute to the paradigm shift that is required to embed projects in sustainable development (Eslerod & Huemann, 2013) by better balancing stakeholders’ needs at the economic, environmental, and social levels. Relatedly, our framework also contributes to normative stakeholder theory, clarifying how the moral notions of reciprocity and capabilities are relevant to managing stakeholder interests in a project management context. Second, addressing criticisms of community engagement in project management, the reciprocity framework we propose takes local needs as a central consideration. Our framework thus emphasizes a long-term orientation to community engagement, building on (Dyllick & Muff, 2016, p. 156) progressive model of sustainable development. Through our framework, our paper responds to the criticism of (Carvalho and Rabechini Jr 2017, p. 1120), who recently suggested that “despite the importance of

sustainability, surprisingly little explicit guidance exists on including this subject in project management literature". Third, our normative approach to examining community engagement furthers knowledge of the concept of capacity building, the act of "developing the capacity and skills of the members of a community in such a way that they are better able to identify and help meet their needs and to participate more fully in society" (Charity Commission, 2000, p. 2). While widespread in both academic literature and practice, capacity building has been criticized for being too abstract of a concept and thus difficult to translate into action (Ika & Donnelly, 2019). By applying the capabilities perspective to the context of extractive industries, we posit a set of specific needs of local communities, which thereby allows us to prescribe actions required of firms in the extractive industry to ensure capacity building.

2. The growing concern for sustainability in project management

In a recent literature review on sustainable project management strategies, Aarseth, Ahola, Aaltonen, Økland, & Andersen, 2017, p. 1071) argue that "research focusing on sustainability in a project context is still nascent and fragmented". It is in fact only very recently that project management scholars have begun to take an interest in sustainable development (Gareis, Huemann, & Martinuzzi, 2013), resulting in the development of the concept of "sustainable project management", which refers to the ways in which project management can be the impetus for sustainable development (Tam, 2010). Silvius & Schipper, 2014, p. 79) define sustainable project management as "the planning, monitoring and controlling of project delivery and support processes, with consideration of the environmental, economic and social aspects of the life-cycle of the project's resources, processes, deliverables, and effects, aimed at realizing benefits for stakeholders, and performed in a transparent, fair and ethical way that includes proactive stakeholder participation". A fundamental tenet of sustainable project management is that project success should be evaluated based on the triple bottom line (economic, social and environmental dimensions).

Given that a long-term orientation is synonymous with the triple bottom line, the implication is that "the success of the project is assessed based on the life cycle of the project and its outcome" (Silvius & Schipper, 2014, p. 75). Several literature reviews and qualitative studies on sustainability and project management highlight the increasing interest in this area of research (Aarseth, Ahola, Aaltonen, Økland, & Andersen, 2017; Carvalho & Rabechini Jr, 2017; Silvius & Schipper, 2014). Khalifeh, Farrell, & Al-edenat (2019) for instance, suggest that integrating sustainability in project management may improve their success. With sustainability being amongst the most pressing challenges humanity is currently facing, the need to better integrate the three dimensions of sustainability into project management studies is widely acknowledged in the literature (Martens & Carvalho, 2016, 2017 Sabini, Muzio, & Alderman, 2019).

A key challenge of integrating sustainability in project management studies is that the concept of sustainability is "understood by instinct, but difficult to express in concrete, operational terms" (Silvius, Kamping, Paniagua, & Mooi, 2017, p. 1134). It is perhaps for this reason that there is little consensus regarding what 'sustainability' means from a project studies perspective (Sabini, Muzio, & Alderman, 2019). Accordingly, many studies in recent years have focused on a better understanding of the practical implications of sustainable development for project management. For example, Aarseth et al. (2017) identify eight sustainable project management strategies. Regarding the operational integration of sustainability in construction projects, Banihashemi, et al. (2017) have suggested several critical success factors based on a comprehensive literature review, categorizing success factors according to the stage in the project lifecycle. Also, Abidin and Pasquire (2007) developed a framework for projects in the construction industry that take into consideration sustainability at the level of inputs, processes, and outputs of a project. Kivilä, Martinsuo, & Vuorinen, 2017 (p. 1167)

empirically demonstrated that sustainability within infrastructure projects requires indicators but also a "holistic control package" whereby governance plays a key role.

Discussions of sustainable development in project studies have paid growing attention to stakeholders, particularly local communities. Local communities are considered amongst the most legitimate stakeholders of extractive industry firms because of the environmental and social consequences they suffer as a direct result of their proximity to extractive projects (Delannon, Raufflet, & Baba, 2016). It is for this reason that social movements in opposition to high-impact projects, whether organized and focused on building credibility or unorganized and focused on escalating conflict (Nguyen, Chileshe, Rameezdeen, & Wood, 2019), are centered around the rights of local communities (Kraemer, Whiteman, & Banerjee, 2013). We follow rural sociology by defining community as "a place-oriented process of interrelated actions through which members of a local population express a shared sense of identity while engaging in the common concerns of life" (Theodori, 2005, pp. 662–663). While a local community may consist of various actors and groups, they are therefore conceptualized in our paper as having common interests and shared norms (Agrawal & Gibson, 1999). Precisely, we conceive members of a local community to have a common desire that extractive projects produce sustainable local benefits, including the development of capabilities that constitute individual community members' freedom to achieve. Project management studies focused on community stakeholders have tended to emphasize the critical success factors for community-driven development projects (Yalegama, Chileshe, & Ma, 2016), the influence of local communities on projects (Derakhshan, Mancini, & Turner, 2019; Di Maddaloni & Davis, 2017; van den Ende & van Marrewijk, 2019), the inclusion and participation of local communities in projects (Sadiqi, Trigunarsyah, & Coffey, 2017; Teo & Loosemore, 2017), and the tensions inherent to community engagement (Cuganesan & Floris, 2020).

Although there are some exceptions (e.g. Aarseth, Ahola, Aaltonen, Økland, & Andersen, 2017), existing project management literature typically adopts an instrumental vision of sustainable development. As a result, the challenges experienced by local communities are omitted as a central consideration for project management decisions. While organizations identify ethics and accountability as critical factors that influence approaches to community engagement (Derakhshan, Turner, & Mancini, 2019), a central issue with community engagement in projects that negates their influence in practice is that the overarching value constructs the firm defines for a project do not align with those of its stakeholders (Eslerod & Ang, 2017). For example, project success is often defined from the firm's perspective rather than that of its stakeholders, with community engagement being used as a means to strategically manage and engender support from the local community to get projects approved, as well as to improve the performance of projects (Aaltonen, Kujala, Havela, & Savage, 2015; Cuganesan & Floris, 2020; Di Maddaloni & Davis, 2018).

A related issue is that community engagement in project management is criticized for being heavily concentrated at initial phases of a project when the buy-in of local communities is most important, instead of being sustained throughout the lifecycle of the project (El-Gohary, Osman, & El-Diraby, 2006; Missonier & Loufrani-Fedida, 2014). This is a significant oversight that leads to stakeholder dissatisfaction, given that success criteria from the perspective of stakeholders, including their own strategic objectives, shift during the progression of the project lifecycle (Eslerod & Vaagaasar, 2014). As such, organizations are required to re-establish their legitimacy on an ongoing basis throughout the lifecycle of the project (van den Ende & van Marrewijk, 2019). This entails engaging local communities in a manner that improves their condition over the long run through ongoing efforts to create mutually beneficial outcomes for both the project promoter and the local community (Delannon, Raufflet, & Baba, 2016; Derakhshan, Mancini, & Turner, 2019; Raufflet, 2014). Despite acknowledgment in the literature that the social impacts of projects are of crucial importance for project

managers, especially for those large-impact development projects in extractive industries (Edum-Fotwe & Price, 2009), notably lacking is a consideration of the social dimension of sustainability. With some exceptions, such as the growing body of research on social value and social procurement that aims to better understand what constitutes social value and how it can be created and effectively measured in practice (Denny-Smith, Williams, & Loosemore, 2020; Loosemore, 2016), the literature on sustainability in project management largely maintains a narrow focus on the economic and environmental impacts of projects (Martens & Carvalho, 2017). Thus, the literature provides limited guidance for how firms can ensure their projects can be a vehicle for sustainable community development.

The limitations of project management for contributing to sustainable development become apparent in the context of the extractive industries when considering existing approaches to community engagement (Bowen, Newenham-Kahindi, & Herremans, 2010, p. 297). The literature on community engagement (Delannion, Raufflet, & Baba, 2016; Mitra, 2016; Muthuri, Chapple, & Moon, 2009; Muthuri, Moon, & Idemudia, 2012; Rowe, Nowak, Quaddus, & Naude, 2013) recognizes various forms and typologies of engagement. In their systematic literature review on the topic, Bowen, Newenham-Kahindi, & Herremans (2010) conceptualized two broad engagement strategies, transactional and transformational, that frame the range of possible community engagement approaches followed by firms in extractive industries to meet stakeholder expectations¹. The transactional strategy represents the earliest attempts at community engagement in the extractive industries and is still prevalent globally (Delannion, Raufflet, & Baba, 2016; Raufflet, Barin-Cruz, & Brès, 2014), especially in institutional contexts in which standards for firm accountability are low (Bird, 2016).

The transactional strategy, as described by Bowen, Newenham-Kahindi, & Herremans, 2010, is representative of the earliest attempts at community engagement in the extractive industries (Delannion, Raufflet, & Baba, 2016; Raufflet, 2014). Under a transactional strategy, firms cultivate relationships with local communities that are paternalistic in nature, the result of which furthers the economic dependence of communities on firms and their projects. Transactional strategies are centered on “giving back” to the community through investment and information, with initiatives that include charitable donations, employee volunteering, and skills training of community members (Bowen, Newenham-Kahindi, & Herremans, 2008). Since transactional strategies entail sporadic, one-way communication with communities, these investments and initiatives are undertaken based on limited consultation with community members regarding their present and evolving needs. As a result, transactional strategies are thought to be largely instrumental in nature, inadequate for addressing local needs and generating long-term economic and social benefits for a community (Delannion, Raufflet, & Baba, 2016).

Transformational strategy is considered the most proactive means of community engagement with the most significant economic and environmental impact on local communities (Bowen, Newenham-Kahindi, & Herremans, 2010) and has emerged in the extractive industries as a response to criticisms that earlier forms of community engagement

failed to produce sustainable benefits for communities (Alves, Ferreira, & Araújo, 2020; Delannion, Raufflet, & Baba, 2016). Transformational strategies aim to “change society” beyond what can be achieved by basic philanthropy and strategic consultation, integrating local communities in the planning, development, and operations of a project. This represented a radical departure from community engagement efforts of the past by involving symmetrical, two-way communication between firms and community stakeholders; learning and sense-making that is jointly generated (Hart & Sharma, 2004); greater control provided to community stakeholders over the project through joint project management (Parker & Selsky, 2004); community leadership in decision-making (Boehm, 2005); and co-ownership (Tracey, Phillips, & Haugh, 2005). Even the most transformative community engagement strategies have failed to meet stakeholder expectations for sustainability; while communities may be involved in the governance of projects through co-management, local sustainability issues are not typically a central consideration (Kemp & Owen, 2013b; Labelle & Pasquero, 2006; Syn, 2014). As a result, transformative community engagement approaches result in dependency between the local community and the firm, as well as unexpected social issues when the project ends, due to a lack of consideration of the long-term effects of the project. Despite their focus on deeper collaborations with local communities, transformational strategies still follow an inherently firm-centric approach in which the primary consideration is how a firm can acquire a social license to operate for its project (Delannion, Raufflet, & Baba, 2016; Raufflet, 2014).

These key deficiencies in the project management literature indicate significant opportunities to expand our understanding of how projects can generate sustainable outcomes for local communities (Martens & Carvalho, 2017; Silvius & Schipper, 2014). Thus far, the project management literature on stakeholder management has largely given secondary consideration to local communities because they have less power to control project resources relative to other stakeholders, even though they face the brunt of the environmental and social consequences (Di Maddaloni & Davis, 2017). In practice, sustainability is recognized as a growing concern for organizations, but there remains a disconnect between the concern for sustainability and the implementation of sustainable project management practices (Martens & Carvalho, 2017). As Eskerod & Huemann (2013, p. 39) suggest, stakeholder issues are treated superficially in project management standards, so much so that a paradigm shift in the foundational values of project stakeholder management is required for projects to address the pressing needs of local communities and achieve sustainable development. Our reciprocity framework, by offering a normative perspective on community engagement that defines project success in terms of the development of capabilities of the local community, is a step towards this paradigm shift.

3. Theoretical framework: The capability approach and the principle of reciprocity

The fundamental issue with instrumental approaches to community engagement is that they conceive of communities in primarily or exclusively instrumental terms—communities matter normatively insofar as they contribute, or detract from, the firm’s achievement of its goals. This is an appropriate way to regard objects and tools. It is not, however, a proper way to consider communities. Communities are composed of individual people—people who have goals of their own. To conceive of and treat them as mere instruments is to fail to respect them as persons (Darwall, 2006; Kant, 2002/1785). As an alternative to instrumental theories of community engagement, we propose a normative approach that centers on two ideas: reciprocity and capabilities.

The moral principle of reciprocity refers to the idea that when one party P benefits from interacting with or relating to another party Q, it is at least a good thing, and in some cases an obligation, for P to return some of that benefit to Q (Schmidtz, 2006). It can thus be distinguished

¹ A third type of community engagement strategy is identified in Bowen, Newenham-Kahindi, & Herremans, 2010, called transitional strategy. It is considered an intermediate form of transactional strategy that is less impactful to community outcomes than a transformational strategy. To illustrate, a transitional strategy moves beyond the one-way, top-down communication of transactional approaches but decisions are not jointly determined as they are in transformational approaches. The exchange of resources moves beyond the one-off donations of transactional approaches to a sharing of resources via collaboration with the community, however resources remain solely owned by the firm rather than jointly with the community. We do not discuss transitional strategy since the key deficiencies of transactional and transformational approaches are sufficient to highlight the range of criticisms of prevailing community engagement approaches (see also Delannion, Raufflet, & Baba, 2016).

from moral considerations of charity or beneficence, which are about promoting the good, irrespective of any particular relationship between the relevant parties (Beauchamp, 2019). We can understand the principle of reciprocity to reflect an obligation of fairness toward members of local communities: when individual people or groups accept the benefits of a mutually-beneficial scheme of cooperation, avoiding morally impermissible free-riding implies a duty on the part of the involved persons and groups to cooperate in proportion to the benefit they enjoy (Hart, 1955; Phillips, 1997; Rawls, 1964). In the extractive project context that is our focus in this paper, one or more firms and their stakeholders will typically stand to benefit significantly from an extractive project whose success requires cooperation on the part of a local community—for example, by agreeing not to oppose the project, and by agreeing to tolerate the project's social and environmental costs.

The principle of reciprocity tells us that in such situations, firms involved in extractive projects should return some good to local communities in proportion to the benefit the firms derive from the project. But how? To which sorts of projects and initiatives should a firm that is involved in an extractive project and is committed to sustainability contribute? The principle of reciprocity itself does not provide an answer to this question: it says only that a party that benefits from a reciprocal relationship must return some of that benefit, but does not specify the form that that benefit should take.

We can develop a more detailed, more specific understanding of the good that firms involved in extractive projects must return to local communities in order to satisfy the principle of reciprocity by reflecting on what constitutes the social well-being, or 'good,' of local communities. One conceptual issue that will immediately confront an attempt to do this is whether the 'good' of local communities is an individualist or a collectivist notion. In other words, when we speak of a community's good, are we just speaking about the aggregated goods of all individual people who are members of the community in question? Or, alternatively, is the community's good determined at least in part by features that do not reduce to the good of individuals? (Epstein, 2018)

An assumption of our analysis, to help make this question about the good of communities more tractable, is that a community's good is understood in terms of the good of the individuals who are members of the community. It seems to us that any plausible theory of the good of a community must at least take the good of individuals into account; dismissing the relevance of the good of any individual person fails to treat individual human beings with the basic minimal moral consideration to which they are entitled. The normative perspective that we offer in this paper is thus ultimately grounded at the individual level. We propose using this individual level of normative analysis to inform project management theorizing focused at the community level.

Now that we have clarified that we understand the good of a community in terms of the good of individuals, the question that we must answer becomes: in what does the good of individuals consist? How are we to understand what it means for a person's life to go well, versus poorly? Normative ethical theories of well-being provide a variety of potential answers to this question (Crisp, 2017). Three of the most prominent theories of well-being are hedonistic utilitarianism; the subjective preference-satisfaction utilitarianism characteristic of orthodox welfare economics; and the capability approach. Hedonistic utilitarianism defines well-being in terms of pleasure and the absence of pain. Subjective preference-satisfaction utilitarianism defines well-being in terms of the extent of the fulfillment of whatever preferences a person happens to have. The capability approach, in contrast to both utilitarian theories, understands well-being in terms of human functionings and capabilities.

We propose the capability approach, rather than hedonistic or subjective preference-satisfaction utilitarianism, as a source of normative guidance for how to fulfill the principle of reciprocity in a project management context. We will first explain the main principles of the capability approach. Then, to justify our choice of the capability approach as a theory of well-being for our reciprocity framework, we

explain the main reasons why we favor the capability approach over the two utilitarian alternatives.

The capability approach, developed by philosophers Martha Nussbaum and Amartya Sen (Nussbaum, 2000, 2011; Sen, 1980, 2009), is designed to evaluate the well-being of individuals for the purpose of assessing social arrangements and proposals for public policy reform. It prioritizes "peoples' beings and doings and their opportunities to realize those beings and doings" (Robeyns, 2016). In other words, the capability approach holds that people's functioning—the activities they can undertake and the states they can realize—should be the normative criteria upon which we base evaluations of human well-being. In practical applications, it offers an alternative to more narrow economic metrics, such as Gross National Product, that policymakers commonly rely on as a proxy for human well-being.²

This philosophical 'capability approach' comes from a different academic literature than the notion of 'capacity building' (or development) that has been developed in project management studies (Ika & Donnelly, 2017; McEvoy, Brady, & Munck, 2016). However, both share significant overlapping concerns: empowering people to identify and meet their own needs, and to be active participants in the social worlds they inhabit. We believe that these two literatures thus have significant potential to complement each other: the capability approach articulates and defends the importance of individual capabilities for normative, ethical theorizing, while capacity building comes from the applied social-scientific field of management, seeking to illuminate the organizational and managerial determinants of successful capacity building. One of our goals in this paper is to begin the work of connecting these two literatures.

To avoid confusion, however, we want to be clear about the somewhat different way in which the notions of 'capability' and 'capacity' are understood in the capability approach versus the project management literature on capacity building. As discussed above, the 'capabilities' at the center of the capability approach are capabilities of individual persons. The capability approach does not deny that organizations, states, and other collective entities can possess capabilities and capacities; however, the capabilities and capacities that it specifies as being of primary moral importance are ones possessed by individuals. Discussion of capacity building in project management, on the other hand, tends to place greater emphasis on capacities of organizations and institutions than on capacities of individuals (e.g. Ika & Donnelly, 2017). Here, following the capability approach, we focus on how projects can contribute to the capacities of individual community members who are affected by extractive projects—individuals Ika and Donnelly (2017) refer to as project 'beneficiaries.'

Examples will help make the central concepts of the capability approach—individual beings and doings—more concrete. Examples of beings include being well-nourished, being sheltered in a comfortable dwelling, and being educated; examples of doings include activities such as caring for a child, volunteering for a charity, engaging in a discussion, and voting in an election (Robeyns, 2016). The relationship between these beings and doings, on the one hand, and capabilities, on the other, is that capabilities represent an individual's positive freedom, or opportunity, to achieve the various beings and doings that, taken together, constitute a good human life (Sen, 1992).

There exist many different specific theories about precisely which

² Note that the concept of 'capabilities' from the capability approach differs from the concept of 'capabilities' from business and strategic management literature. The capability approach's 'capabilities' refer to the human beings, doings, and functionings that are relevant to assessments of human wellbeing and are a component of normative theory. The 'capabilities' from business and strategic management literature are typically employed in social scientific theories whose purpose is to explain the causes of sustained competitive advantage; they refer to sets of routines or activities that an organization's management relies on to produce significant outputs (Winter, 2003).

capabilities, and which corresponding beings and doings, are of more pressing importance from a normative point of view. Any list of capabilities that one comes up with is bound to be controversial: the question of which capabilities are most important implicates questions about values that are themselves controversial. Bearing this inherent difficulty in mind, however, Martha Nussbaum has proposed a fairly succinct yet expansive list of ten central capabilities based on her conception of what is required of a life worthy of human dignity.

They include (paraphrased from Nussbaum, 2011, pp. 33–34): (1) being able to live a human life of normal length; (2) being able to have good bodily health, adequate nourishment, and adequate shelter; (3) being able to have bodily integrity, including freedom of movement, security against violent assault, and having opportunities for sexual satisfaction and choice over reproduction; (4) being able to use one's senses and capacity to imagine, think, and reason, including to produce works and events, to express one's thoughts, and to have pleasurable experiences and avoid pain; (5) being able to feel, express, and process one's emotions including "to love, to grieve, to experience longing, gratitude, and justified anger" (33); (6) being able to form an idea of the good for oneself and to critically reflect on one's life plans; (7) being able to affiliate with other humans, to engage in various kinds of social interaction, to imagine the situation of others, and to enjoy the social bases of self-respect; (8) being able to live with, and with concern for, animals, plants, and nature more generally; (9) being able to laugh and play; and (10) being able to participate in political choices that affect one's life, to hold property and seek employment on an equal basis with others, and to enter into meaningful, mutually respectful relationships in one's workplace.

As a theory for sustainable project management, the capability approach has important advantages compared to both the hedonistic and the subjective preference-satisfaction varieties of utilitarianism (Sen, 1980). Utilitarian theories rely on categories such as the fulfillment of subjective preferences, or happiness or pleasure, and absence of pain to define what it means for human life to go well. The capability approach, by contrast, focuses on developing individuals' capabilities to enjoy certain goods that are constitutive of human happiness — e.g. for Nussbaum, the ability to laugh and play, to live with animals and nature, to love, to express oneself and produce creative works — but not on the actual achievement of the subjective state of being happy. In our view, as a normative theory for sustainable project management, this focus is entirely appropriate. In the domain of project management, the relevant agents are business firms, on the one hand, and community members, on the other. Thus, a normative theory about project management should inform the decisions of managers of business firms. Above, we object to transactional community engagement strategies due to concerns about paternalism and dependency. For the same reasons, we believe that it is inappropriate to hold business firms and their managers responsible for community members' happiness.

Suppose, for example, that members of a local community affected by a project suffer from high rates of obesity and associated health problems. Members of the community would likely be happier if they exercised more and ate healthier diets. Does this mean that a firm involved in this project should interfere in the lives of these community members to ensure that they eat healthy food? Surely not. Political philosophers disagree about whether it is a proper role of government to implement paternalist policies aimed at getting citizens to make better choices (e.g. Conly, 2012; De Marneffe, 2006; Dworkin, 2005). But even defenders of government paternalism are unlikely to support paternalism by business firms toward community members: unlike democratic governments, business firms are not accountable to the people living in the communities they inhabit and are primarily governed to further ends that are private as opposed to public (Anderson, 2017).

The capability approach allows us to flesh out the obligations of firms that occupy reciprocal relationships with communities in a way that treats community members as responsible, autonomous moral agents in their own right. Rather than insisting that sustainable project

management must ensure community members' happiness or health, we should expect sustainable project management to contribute to bringing about the conditions that allow community members to achieve happiness and health for themselves. This conviction supports the capability approach, rather than utilitarian alternatives, as a supplement to the principle of reciprocity and moves us closer to an adequate normative theory of sustainable project management.

The core dimensions of sustainable community engagement are commonly understood along the dimensions of people, planet, prosperity, peace, and partnership, as defined by the United Nations (United Nations, 2015). Paralleling the recent work of Boiral, Heras-Saizarbitoria, and Brotherton (2019) on community engagement with indigenous peoples in extractive industries, Table 1 builds on these core dimensions to map specific issues in the extractive industries that threaten to undermine each dimension of sustainability for local communities, the capabilities that these issues implicate (as per the Nussbaum (2011) classification), and actions that can be taken to address the sustainability-related issues. This table illustrates that existing issues in extractive industries have direct, negative impacts on the capabilities of local communities. The purpose of the reciprocity framework we present in the next section is to provide a set of general principles, centered on the development of local capabilities, that can guide firms to the various actions needed to address sustainability-related issues in the extractive industries.

4. Meeting stakeholder expectations through local capability development: A reciprocity approach to community engagement

The reciprocity framework reflects a more progressive sustainable development perspective that differs from existing approaches to community engagement by having as its primary consideration the sustainable development issues faced by local communities. We build on what Dyllick and Muff (2016) label as the "true business sustainability," which stands in stark contrast to the business-as-usual view of sustainability. Across these two views of sustainability, there is a "shift in fundamental organizational perspectives, from an inside-out perspective with a focus on the business itself to an outside-in perspective with a focus on society and the sustainability challenges it is facing. This moves the value creation perspective from the triple bottom line to "creating value for the common good" (Dyllick & Muff, 2016, p. 168).

Our reciprocity framework suggests that to have a sustainable impact on local communities, a reciprocal and equitable exchange of resources must occur. In exchange for the extraction of inherently non-renewable natural resources — the act of which can have severe negative environmental and social consequences on local communities — firms should create and reinforce local capabilities. These capabilities serve as a benchmark, in the form of explicit beings and functionings for individual members of the community, that extractive projects need to protect and promote by mitigating the negative impacts of their projects or by actively contributing to local development. The development of local capabilities ensures the conditions that allow community members to achieve positive life outcomes in the form of sustained benefits that endure beyond the conclusion of a project (Jeans, Thomas, & Castillo, 2016; Smits, Justinussen, & Bertelsen, 2016). As such, the reciprocity framework is aligned with the contemporary, sustainability-centric view of stakeholder expectations in which philanthropy, project-driven investment in infrastructure, and the creation of temporary jobs are insufficient to offset the environmental and social costs borne by current and future generations of the local community (Delannon, Raufflet, & Baba, 2016; Parsons, Lacey, & Moffat, 2014; Richert, Rogers, & Burton, 2015).

We distinguish the reciprocity approach from transactional and transformational approaches in terms of four key dimensions that we have inductively identified based on our understanding of the vast literature that focuses on community engagement and sustainability (e.g. Bowen, Newenham-Kahindi, & Herremans, 2010; Delannon, Raufflet,

Table 1

Sustainability issues in the extractive industries and their impacts on community members capabilities.

Sustainability dimensions	Issues in the extractive industries	Capabilities compromised due to issues (Nussbaum, 2011)
People: “end poverty and hunger, in all their forms and dimensions, and to ensure that all human beings can fulfill their potential in dignity and equality and in a healthy environment.”	- Pegg (2006, p. 376) argues that “mining is more likely to lead to poverty exacerbation than it is to poverty reduction,” illustrating the ‘resource curse’ associated with extractive industries - A lack of consideration of local needs has resulted in indigenous communities feeling that large corporations have appropriated their traditional lands to which their cultural identities and traditional values are tied, resulting in adverse cultural and psychological consequences (Boiral, Heras-Saizarbitoria, & Brotherton, 2019; Grzybowski, 2012). - In many cases, the geographic delocalization of local communities is undertaken without adequate financial compensation, at best providing economic benefits that are only short-term (St-Laurent & Le Billon, 2015; Harvey, 2014). - In remote communities, the “Dutch disease” and “Fly-in Fly-out” phenomena make them more economically vulnerable.	- Poverty and the exclusion from extractive projects challenge the ability of local community members to live a human life of standard length (capability 1), as well as their ability to have good health, adequate nourishment, and shelter (capabilities 2, 3). - Moreover, the historic exclusion of indigenous communities and the neglect of their traditional values and lifestyle challenges their ability to form an idea of the good for oneself and to critically reflect on one’s life plans (capability 6). - Furthermore, forced delocalization and expropriation challenge the ability of community members to affiliate with other humans and engage in various social interactions (capability 7).
Planet: “protect the planet from degradation [...] taking urgent action on climate change, so that it can support the needs of the present and future generations.”	- Oil and gas extraction have severely affected the environment and climate of both developing and developed countries (Bell & Donnelly, 2006). - Land and soil pollution, the use of highly toxic chemicals, air and water pollution from the disposal of waste, and the intensive use of water are amongst the most documented environmental issues (Böhling, Murguía, & Godfrid, 2019; Frederiksen, 2019). - Overall, extractive industries have a poor record in managing the environmental consequences of their activities (Schrecker, Birn, & Aguilara, 2018).	- The recurrent negative impacts of extractive projects on the environment and ecosystems challenge the ability of community members to live a human life of normal length (capability 1). - Moreover, within indigenous communities whose lives depend naturally on wildlife, the negative environmental impacts of extractive projects challenge their ability to have good bodily health, adequate nourishment, and adequate shelter (capability 2), as well as their ability to live with animals, plants, and nature in general (capability 8)

Table 1 (continued)

Sustainability dimensions	Issues in the extractive industries	Capabilities compromised due to issues (Nussbaum, 2011)
Prosperity: “ensure that all human beings can enjoy prosperous and fulfilling lives and that economic, social and technological progress occurs in harmony with nature.”	- An important criticism pertaining to the social performance of extractive industries is the unfair distribution of benefits relative to the associated impact they have on local communities (Kemp, Owen, Gotzmann, & Bond, 2011; Söderholm & Svahn, 2015) - Projects worldwide demonstrate that benefit-sharing in the extractive industries is frequently opaque and inequitable (Renouard, 2011; World Bank, 2003) - Local communities feel they deserve a stake in the financial wealth generated “on their backs” (Grzybowski, 2012). Consequently, benefit-sharing in the extractive industries has become an important topic at the United Nations, where the meaning of what is considered ‘fair’ and ‘equitable’ is being re-examined and re-evaluated (Jonge, 2011).	- Taken together, because of adverse effects on physical health, mental health, and communities’ spiritual loss due to the impacts on their environments, indigenous communities experience a lasting threat to their ability to laugh and play (capability 9). - When extractive projects generate economic value for certain shareholders and to the detriment of local communities, this economic injustice impedes the ability of community members to have good bodily health, adequate nourishment, and adequate shelter, especially in remote and unfavoured communities (capability 2); - A lack of benefit-sharing of extractive projects limits the ability of local community members to live pleasurable, flourishing lives in which they enjoy the opportunities for creativity and self-expression (capability 4). - From an economic perspective, a lack of benefit-sharing of extractive projects can prevent members of a local community from having the opportunity to hold property and work in jobs that are dignified and meaningful (capability 10)
Peace: “foster peaceful, just and inclusive societies which are free from fear and violence.”	- Extractive projects often contribute to the erosion of social cohesion in communities by increasing fragmentation (Maher, 2019) - For example, ethnic and armed conflicts can be fueled by mining activities (Stevens, Kooroshy, Lahn, & Lee, 2013). A United Nations report highlights that 40% of civil wars during the past six decades or so have been associated with natural resources (United Nations, 2012)	- Conflicts and wars that are partly caused by the actions (or inactions) of extractive industries result in adverse consequences to human health and happiness (capabilities 1, 2, 9), the natural environment (capability 8), and individual autonomy and freedom (capability 10)

(continued on next page)

Table 1 (continued)

Sustainability dimensions	Issues in the extractive industries	Capabilities compromised due to issues (Nussbaum, 2011)
	- Extractive industries are closely linked to violent conflict in a variety of forms “often obscured by more visible drivers such as ethnic tensions,” where the root cause is “competition to control or gain access to natural resources” (Grzybowski, 2012, p. 9) - Communities and local stakeholders are too often excluded from the consultation process regarding the development of extractive projects (Frederiksen, 2019; Kraemer, Whiteman, & Banerjee, 2013; Ofori & Ofori, 2019).	- When extractive projects directly or indirectly contribute to ethnic and social conflicts, they weaken the institutions that maintain stability in communities. The “peace” dimension is therefore pivotal for sustainability in the sense that the fragility of institutions is the mother of all evils. Without institutional stability and peace, all capabilities are weakened.

- We do not include one of the P's, “partnership”, suggested by the United Nations. The reason for this exclusion is because our framework focuses specifically on the role of the organization promoting an extractive project, whereas the partnership dimension advocates for transnational cooperation of a wider spectrum of actors.

- Fly-in fly-out is a method of employing human resources in remote areas, often used in the extractive industries. This method does not give many opportunities to local communities to develop their capacities and take up decent jobs. Furthermore, the Dutch disease refers to the idea that communities that depend too much on natural resources usually end up under developing other sectors such as manufacturing.

& Baba, 2016; Dyllick & Muff, 2016): focus, value creation horizon, type of value creation, and dependency resulting from the project. The key characteristics of the approach and how it differs from existing community engagement strategies are summarized in Table 2.

4.1. Focus

The reciprocity approach to managing firm-community relations in the extractive industries calls for a paradigm shift in the way organizations approach their relations with local stakeholders (Boiral, Heras-Saizarbitoria, & Brotherton, 2019; Neville, Bell, & Whitwell, 2011; Pasquero, 2008). Transactional approaches based on reactive conflict management are firm-centered as they overemphasize firms' interests to the detriment of those of their local communities (Baba & Raufflet, 2014). Transformational approaches, although attempting to address local issues by involving communities in the management of a project, are also firm-centric since the needs and interests of the firm remain the starting point for any collaboration (Delannon, Raufflet, & Baba, 2016). The reciprocity framework requires firms to first understand the needs of their local environment before designing their project in coherence with these needs. Developing capabilities among members of the local community becomes a central focus of a project, rather than a peripheral concern that is only relevant to the focal firm insofar as developing capabilities is instrumental to the firm's own private interest.

Following the capability approach, a key starting point of an extractive project would be the community's most critical challenges with respect to building community members' capabilities. The reciprocity framework would determine, through consultation with community members, which capabilities are most valuable and which capabilities community members are unable to enjoy under status quo arrangements. The results of these inquiries would help define the central goals of the community engagement initiative. In following an

Table 2

Comparison of the Reciprocity Framework with Existing Community Engagement Strategies.

	Transactional	Transformational	Reciprocity
Focus	<i>Firm centered</i> The needs of the firm take priority over the needs of the community	<i>Firm centered</i> The needs of the firm are the starting point for collaboration	<i>Community centered</i> The needs of the local community are central, and a project is designed in coherence with these needs <i>Beyond the project</i>
Value creation horizon	<i>Strictly project-bounded</i> Initiatives are undertaken during the lifetime of the project for the purpose of alleviating stakeholder pressure	<i>Mostly project-bounded</i> Social and sustainability issues are prioritized, but the value created from these initiatives is bound by the project's lifetime	Emphasis on long-term value creation that is sustained after the project ceases to operate
Type of value creation	<i>Refined shareholder value</i> Financial-oriented value created through philanthropic investments	<i>Triple bottom line</i> Value is created and balanced along economic, environmental, and social dimensions	<i>Capability Building</i> Conception of value from a project relies on an understanding of what is necessary for community members to be able to live flourishing lives
Dependency resulting from the project	<i>Very dependent</i> Paternalistic approach to community engagement that generates dependency and is thus at odds with generating sustainable benefits	<i>Partially dependent</i> Value creation is largely project bounded. Thus, the value created along economic, environmental, and social dimensions is not sustainable	<i>Independent</i> Focus is on empowering local communities to foster healthy societies and economies independent of a firm's project

outward perspective, a firm needs to assess “the external environment within which it operates and then ask itself what it can do to help overcome critical challenges that demand the resources and competencies it has at its disposal” (Dyllick & Muff, 2016, p. 11). Relying on the 4P's of sustainable community engagement that we have sketched in Table 1, it is possible to consider a focus around four dimensions: people, planet, prosperity, and peace. As previously suggested, there are opportunities for building local capabilities that correspond to each dimension, which would entail rectifying issues characteristic in the extractive industries.

For example, in regards to the ‘people’ dimension, indigenous communities often experience cultural and psychological trauma due to what they perceive as an appropriation of their traditional lands to which their identities and values are tied (Grzybowski, 2012; Whiteman, 2004). This results in a lack of fulfillment of capabilities pertaining to living healthy and prosperous lives, in large part due to compromising the social cohesion of the community. Since social cohesion can be considered significant in indigenous communities in light of the collective nature of their cultures (Hart, 2010; Mrabure, 2019; Baba & Fortin-Lefebvre 2021), a key focus of extractive industry projects in these contexts should be to nurture relational capabilities “which emphasize the quality of the social climate and of the inter-dependencies within a given group or political community” (Renouard, 2011, p. 90).

In regards to community engagement, this would entail firms prioritizing the development of the local community's social environment over material resources through means such as people-centric corporate social responsibility strategies that assess human development in both the short and long-term (Renouard & Ezvan, 2017).

4.2. Value creation horizon

The reciprocity approach calls for a long-term value creation horizon for community-engagement strategies that extends beyond the conclusion of the project. Transactional strategies are short-term in nature, based mainly on symbolic initiatives that serve as a temporary means of alleviating stakeholder pressure (Bowen, Newenham-Kahindi, & Herremans, 2010; Delannon, Raufflet, & Baba, 2016). Transformational strategies prioritize social and sustainability issues, but in a way that is bounded by the life span of the project. However, the ethical issues of benefit sharing tend to become especially salient once a project concludes, at which time communities are often left with a compromised ecological and social environment and inadequate sustainable long-term benefits stemming from the firm's attempts at local transformation (Chin, Choong, Alwi, & Mohammed, 2014; Jawahar & McLaughlin, 2001; Zyglidopoulos, 2003).

Our framework addresses this shortcoming of transformational strategies by requiring that firms collaborate with local communities with the intention of creating sustainable local benefits not bound by the conclusion of a project. According to the capability approach, what matters when evaluating a policy or initiative is not just people's capabilities at a given point in time but people's capabilities over the span of their lives. Furthermore, the capability approach can be extended to include members of future generations, rather than just people who are alive in the present time (Ballet, Koffi, & Pelenc, 2013; Martins, 2011). As such, sustainable community development from the perspective of the reciprocity framework addresses current needs as well as the needs of future generations, which will be impacted by today's activities. That is not to say that a firm that develops a 25-year activity plan in a local community must commit to collaborative projects that extend indefinitely into the future. Instead, during its 25-year collaboration with the local community, the firm must strive to develop local capabilities that will add value to the community beyond the duration of the project (i.e., Smits, Justinussen, & Bertelsen, 2016).

A good example of a long-term value creation horizon is Hydro-Québec's engagement with the Cree First Nations as part of their Eastmain1A-Sarcelle-Rupert hydroelectric project that began in 2002. The project was situated in the Eeyou Istchee, the Cree First Nation traditional territory located in the area of James Bay, northern Quebec. This five billion-dollar project aimed to divert the Rupert River partially and to build two powerhouses. The parties have agreed to a profit-sharing arrangement that will be active for as long as the hydropower project is in operation; that is, for at least a century if the average life of a dam is taken into account (Baba et al., 2016). Several components of this agreement resulted in the development of capabilities. For example, Crees were trained to occupy technical positions in the stations that were reserved for them, which provided meaningful opportunities for work and the personal fulfillment associated with it. Furthermore, this hydro project stimulated local entrepreneurship by outsourcing contracts to entrepreneurs. For example, individuals from the community were put in charge of socio-environmental impact studies, providing immediate autonomy and freedom that could be sustained in the long-term by leveraging the skills developed to contracts outside their community. This very long-term vision of community engagement is indicative of Hydro-Québec's commitment to generate social and economic value locally at all stages of the project's life cycle, contrary to mainstream practices in which benefits to communities are incurred at the beginning of the project (Raufflet, 2014). To further formalize its long-term focus, Hydro-Québec has also committed to deploying financial and material resources aimed at managing and resolving unforeseen environmental

problems throughout the life cycle of the hydroelectric dam, which can be at least a century.

4.3. Type of value creation

Value creation in the reciprocity framework echoes Dyllick & Muff's (2016, p. 10–11) more progressive view of sustainability which "shifts its perspective from seeking to minimize its negative impacts to understanding how it can create a significant positive impact in critical and relevant areas for society and the planet." While the typical conception of value creation for local stakeholders is financial-oriented and motivated by philanthropy, the reciprocity framework posits a more holistic conception of value (i.e., beyond solely economic value) created as a result of firm-community collaborations that empower community members through the development of their capabilities (i.e., Raufflet, 2014). In doing so, it emphasizes a shift from generating value primarily for shareholders to creating lasting value for local communities. Capability theory can justify policies and initiatives "in terms of non-economic political values, such as social and environmental justice" (Holland, 2014, p. 200). In other words, the capabilities approach provides a conception of the value resulting from a project that is significantly more comprehensive and that relies on a much more plausible idea of what is necessary for humans to live flourishing lives than approaches that conceive of all value in purely economic terms. For example, the capabilities approach calls for local communities to have the ability to co-exist and experience life with animals, plants, and nature in general. Issues often caused by extractive projects such as land, water, and soil pollution, as well as the use of highly toxic chemicals, results in ecological degradation, which compromises local communities' fulfillment of this capability.

The Hydro-Quebec example illustrates how major development projects can nurture local capabilities pertaining to a healthy natural environment. In this specific case, Hydro-Québec operated in an environment where biodiversity and the natural environment are at the heart of the social system (Feit, 1995b; Whiteman & Cooper, 2000), given the intimate relationship with nature that indigenous peoples tend to share (Feit, 1995a). The company developed a partnership with the Crees that involved the community in all the stages of the environmental assessment process. The Crees were involved upstream in the environmental assessment process, aimed at understanding how the Eastmain-1-A/Sarcelle/Rupert diversion hydroelectric project will impact the local ecosystems. The Crees were also involved after the completion of the project to monitor the environmental impacts continuously. Traditional knowledge of the Crees was incorporated in these large-scale studies (Hydro-Québec, 2012). For example, the Wasikaganish Voluntary Anadromous Cisco Catch Registry is "a community-led ex-post monitoring program carried out within the Environmental Impact Assessment (EIA) Follow-up Phase of the Rupert River Diversion Hydroelectric Project" (Strangway, Dunn, & Erless, 2016, p. 1). In light of the complexity of the socio-ecological system, this initiative has "allowed the community to monitor changes in the cisco fishery, while also providing a forum for communication and collaboration with the proponent, Hydro-Québec" (Strangway, Dunn, & Erless, 2016, p. 1). The program recognizes and incorporates both local ecological knowledge and scientific results from site-specific biological monitoring studies" (p. 1). It has contributed to enhancing "stakeholder understanding of project impacts, improved mitigation management decision-making and led to the development of an effective consultation framework" (p. 1). Overall, Hydro-Québec's approach with the Crees contributed to capability building in connection with the support of environmental impact studies and monitoring. By enabling the Crees to be central actors in the environmental assessment process rather than merely subjects (COMEX, 2013), Hydro-Québec's engagement strategy empowered the community to ensure the project is ecologically viable in terms of their cultural perspective, which advocates for the ability to live healthy lives centred around the natural environment (COMEX, 2013).

This example also illustrates that it is essential that community engagement efforts not assume that communities are “deficient – in skills, knowledge and experience” (Craig, 2007, p. 352). This is especially relevant in indigenous contexts where (Lertzman & Vredenburg, 2005) “cultural difference is viewed as a weakness and not a strength, a capacity deficit to be rebuilt or a problem to be “solved” (Tedmanson, 2003, p. 15). Citing an indigenous community member, Tedmanson (2003, p. 15, cited in Craig, 2007, p. 351) offers a thought-provoking message.

To restore capacity in our people is to be responsible for our own future. Notice that I talk of restoring rather than building capacity in our people . . . we had 40 to 60,000 years of survival and capacity. The problem is that our capacity has been eroded and diminished (by White colonialists) – our people do have skills, knowledge and experience . . . we are quite capable of looking after our own children and fighting for their future.

4.4. Dependency resulting from the project

Taken together, the three previous components of the reciprocity approach ensure local communities are empowered to foster a society and economy that can be successful independent of the operations of a firm. Firms can play an active role in this process, for instance, with their commitment to developing entrepreneurial and professional capabilities within the community. The independence of local communities is a crucial issue for sustainable development (Syn, 2014). Several studies show that the natural resources industry, including extractives, can make local communities highly dependent on local projects (Bird, 2016; Humby, 2016; Littlewood, 2014; O’Faircheallaigh, 2015; Raufflet, 2014). “Dutch disease,” a concept from economics, argues that the increase in the development of a specific sector in a region results in the decline of other sectors. Raufflet (2014) illustrates this effect with the Trois-Rivières case in Quebec, Canada. The historic overdependence of the region towards the pulp and paper sector led to other sectors in the area being neglected, which led to a collapse of the local economy when the industry restructured in the 1980s and 1990s and many plants closed (Verrette, 1998).

Paternalistic, transactional approaches that generate dependency are themselves detrimental to firms insofar as they increase local communities’ expectations but fail to deliver sustainable, long-term benefits (Bird, 2016; Kraemer, Whiteman, & Banerjee, 2013). Perhaps surprisingly, even more transformational approaches have tended to create high dependence of local communities on extractive projects, driven by an inward focus that fails to make local needs central in community engagement and a value creation horizon that is mostly project-bounded. Labelle and Pasquero (2006) showed how Alcan followed a paternalistic approach in engaging with the local community in Quebec, where its aluminum operation was situated, resulting in a situation in which the community became a “company town” dependent on Alcan as an employer, infrastructure provider, and landlord. The authors retraced the history of Alcan with the community and showed how this relationship evolved from being paternalistic and dependent to a much more autonomous, independent, and co-constructive relationship based on collaboration and partnership. According to the authors, this example illustrates the progress of a firm that has learned from its contentious relationship with the local community that sustainable community development requires a genuine commitment to forming a long-term partnership.

Nussbaum’s list of capabilities serves as a corrective to these dependency-creating approaches by emphasizing independence. For example, number 6 on Nussbaum’s list is “being able to form an idea of the good for oneself and to critically reflect on one’s life plans,” which implies that individual community members should be able to act as self-authors of their own lives. Another example is number 10 on

Nussbaum’s list, “being able to participate in political choices that affect one’s life and being able to hold property and seek employment on an equal basis with others, being able to enter into meaningful, mutually respectful relationships in one’s workplace.” This capability furthers the notion that individuals should be in control of their own lives, advocating for a degree of collective political autonomy for the community as a whole. As illustrated by the above example, too much dependence on a single company threatens to jeopardize this individual and community autonomy that Nussbaum’s capability approach would require.

5. Contributions and discussion

Our conceptual paper advances research on sustainable project management by explaining how effective community engagement strategies aimed at strengthening local capabilities can contribute to sustainable project management. More specifically, we offer a framework that emphasizes four key components of community engagement strategy conducive to a sustainable project that allows local communities to benefit from it along with the promoter. In so doing, our paper has important implications for research on sustainable project management and community engagement more generally.

5.1. Towards a paradigm shift in our understanding of sustainable project management

The project management literature suggests that a paradigmatic shift in the way project success is conceptualized is required for integrating sustainability into project management (Armenia, Dangelico, Nonino, & Pompei, 2019); the conventional pressures of time, budget and quality need to give way for the social and environmental considerations of projects (Aarseth, Ahola, Aaltonen, Økland, & Andersen, 2017; Eskerod, Huemann, & Ringhofer, 2015). It is clear from the literature that a holistic change in the way project management is designed and practiced will bring us closer to such a standard (Aarseth, Ahola, Aaltonen, Økland, & Andersen, 2017; Gareis et al., 2013; Martens & Carvalho, 2017), yet there is little explicit guidance on how sustainability can be integrated into projects (Carvalho & Rabecchini Jr., 2017). Our reciprocity framework addresses this gap in the literature by taking as its central consideration the capabilities of local community members, thereby prioritizing their ability to lead fulfilling lives as a benchmark of sustainable project management. Our framework adds to Keeyes & Huemann’s (2017) interesting study on how sustainable benefits could be co-created for a varied group of stakeholders through ‘benefits creation’ and ‘benefits capture.’

Our paper thus offers a relevant contribution to the literature that helps reconcile the concept of sustainability with the field of project management, which are often at odds in light of the latter’s tendency to take an instrumental perspective (Eskerod & Huemann, 2013). Amidst increasing expectations of local communities for benefit sharing commensurate with the costs they incur due to extractive projects (Delannon, Raufflet, & Baba, 2016), we offer specific insights for the extractive industries, where frequent controversies have resulted in considerable difficulty for firms in obtaining a social license to operate (Demuijnck & Festerling, 2016; Kemp & Owen, 2013a). Although, we believe our framework can apply to any projects with substantial local impacts such as construction and major development projects. These high-impact projects are typically in a situation of “spatial lock-in” (Torre & Rallet, 2005), meaning their impacts are concentrated in particular territories.

Our reciprocity framework adds clarity to the meaning of capacity building at the local community level. The concept of capacity building, commonly understood as “the process through which individuals, organizations and societies obtain, strengthen and maintain the capabilities to set and achieve their own development objectives over time” (United Nations Development Programme, 2009, p. 4), has been criticized as an “ill-defined umbrella concept” (Ika & Donnelly, 2019, p. 46).

It is, therefore, essential to specify what exactly capacity building means at the local community level in order to advocate for changes in project management practices that can contribute to it. Accordingly, project management scholars have added concreteness to the meaning of local capacity development by identifying critical success factors (Ika, Diallo, & Thuillier, 2012; Ika & Donnelly, 2017) and examining the topic from various theoretical perspectives (e.g. complex adaptive systems, McEvoy, Brady, & Munck, 2016) and gendered perspectives (Brière & Auclair, 2020). Our reciprocity framework, by offering a normative perspective on the capabilities a community should possess to ensure their own sustainable development, maps out what the outcomes of successful local capacity development might look like and the role of project management in the extractive industries for contributing to them.

Furthermore, the reciprocity framework integrates philosophical theories of normative ethics with insights from existing project management literature to inform and justify its prescriptions for project managers. This represents an important methodological advance in project management literature. One deficiency of conventional project management approaches is their tendency to instrumentalize community engagement initiatives to narrow considerations of firm economic performance. We believe that an important reason for this is that much research in the field of project management strives not only to advance our theoretical understanding of empirical phenomena in the domain of project management but also to generate prescriptive guidance for project managers. However, as the philosopher David Hume articulated nearly 300 years ago, empirical facts cannot by themselves yield prescriptive guidance—one cannot derive an ‘ought’ from an ‘is’ (Hume, 1739). In other words, generating and justifying prescriptive guidance requires taking on broad substantive normative assumptions (Donaldson, 2012). Instrumentalizing community engagement activities to the economic performance of a focal firm, for all its shortcomings, at least serves as a normative basis from which prescriptive implications can be derived in a way that is logically valid.

However, although this instrumental approach may be logically sound, it is not morally sound, as project management scholars have in recent years begun to recognize (Cicmil & Hodgson, 2006; Klein, 2016; Sabini, Muzio, & Alderman, 2019; Silvius et al., 2013). An adequate overall theoretical understanding of project management, therefore, requires assessment and analysis of alternative normative bases for prescriptive guidance for project managers (e.g., Jensen, Thuesen, & Geraldi, 2016). This article shows how normative philosophical theories can enrich our understanding of how projects can contribute to sustainable development. We have relied on the capability approach, supplemented with theory about the principle of reciprocity. As we have shown, these theories have significant potential to deepen our understanding of the normative, prescriptive aspects of project management by informing how we think about the goals of projects in extractive industries. Our hope is that the work we have done in this paper to integrate these normative philosophical approaches into our framework will contribute to opening additional avenues for future research by project management scholars that use theories from normative philosophy to inform both theoretical and practical aspects of project management (for an interesting special issue on this topic, see Konstantinou & Müller, 2016).

5.2. Community engagement to foster local capacities in project settings

Our paper also has implications for community engagement strategies. In light of decades of inadequate community engagement in the extractive industries that have made firms the target of considerable scrutiny, we develop in our paper the reciprocity approach to community engagement centered on a more progressive view of sustainability (Dyllick & Muff, 2016), which builds on the philosophical perspective of capability development. The approach is characterized by the core components of having **a)** the perspective that local needs are a central

consideration, **b)** a value creation with a horizon beyond the project, **c)** value creation aimed at fostering local capabilities, and **d)** a focus on ensuring the independence of local communities. We posit that our framework represents a more effective means of community engagement in extractive industries, one which allows projects to fulfill their potential of being a means by which sustainable business practices can be realized (Aarseth et al., 2017; Silvius et al., 2017). In this sense, it is a new basis for community engagement strategy more attuned with modern stakeholder expectations for sustainable development.

Firm-community scholars have focused considerable attention on how firms and local communities can develop and nurture harmonious and constructive relationships (Ali, 2016; Baba & Raufflet, 2014; Bird, 2016; Keenan, Kemp, & Ramsay, 2016; Melé & Armengou, 2016), yet the proposed strategies and approaches have struggled to meet stakeholder expectations (Demuijnck & Fasterling, 2016; Kemp & Owen, 2013a; Melé & Armengou, 2016). This is due primarily to an inward focus in which community engagement centered around obtaining project approval (Di Maddaloni & Davis, 2018; Raufflet, 2014). With this in mind, the reciprocity framework necessarily requires a firm to “go beyond the business case for corporate sustainability” (Dyllick & Hockerts, 2002, p. 130) by making local capability development and the collaborative community relations that support it the primary basis of a proposed project.

The reciprocity framework thus extends the possible approaches to community engagement beyond the three conventional strategies (i.e., transaction, transitional and transformational (Bowen et al., 2008, 2010), in which sustainable development issues of local communities are not necessarily the primary consideration. Characterized by firms’ “deliberately embracing flexibility by adapting to the variety of its local stakeholders’ expectations” (Delannon, Raufflet, & Baba, 2016, p. 715), transactional strategy is contradictory with our framework because it does not take as a starting point the consideration of local stakeholder needs but rather addresses them as a peripheral consideration. On the other end of the community engagement spectrum, transformational strategy, because of the importance it attaches to co-management and the integration of local communities in the governance of projects, is not contradictory with our framework. That being said, we feel that transformational strategy can better consider and address the sustainable development needs of local communities if it is centered around the development of local capabilities.

Key to the focus dimension of the reciprocity framework is the free, prior, and informed consent of local communities (Papillon & Rodon, 2016). A fair and transparent approach to gaining consent will ensure that local communities agree to conditions that improve capabilities that are most pressing to them. Furthermore, this approach would help ensure respect for fundamental human rights, which is especially necessary given that extractive industries are frequently criticized for their human rights records, especially regarding their relationships with indigenous communities. Explicitly, this approach for gaining consent can include the development of protocols for two-way collaboration based on a central focus of community needs, mutually agreed on by the firm and the local community, in which the primary basis for cooperation is how firms and communities can collectively tackle the pressing issues faced by local communities through the development of the project. Such two-way collaboration mechanisms would necessarily be characterized by respect and openness to local values and cultures. Establishing trust with local communities from the earliest point in the project by demonstrating a deep understanding of community structure and dynamics is critical to preventing misconceptions regarding the project (Teo & Loosemore, 2017) and should become an industry-wide priority.

5.3. Research avenues, limitations and conclusion

The insights from our paper bring to light two interesting and relevant research avenues. Firstly, the reciprocity framework is the initial

sketch of a new paradigm for corporate-community engagement strategies, which could better meet local stakeholder expectations for projects in the extractive industries. As an initial sketch, further research will be required to deepen this reciprocity framework by exploring, for example, the specific initiatives that can be taken and the roles of both the firm and community members for fostering local capabilities. The various capabilities of a local community and how they may change in importance across the project lifecycle can be matched with the planning of community engagement initiatives to develop them best. Secondly, future research can assess comparative and cross-industry cases beyond the extractive industries to evaluate how and to what extent the reciprocity framework can help firms in other high-impact industries prone to scrutiny meet stakeholder expectations for more sustainable projects outcomes. We do feel there is sufficient similarity between the extractive industries and other industries with high impact projects that our reciprocity framework could be extended to those industry contexts. However, there may be essential boundary conditions that can be established based on idiosyncrasies of those industries that would reveal themselves under a more critical lens.

Subject to the limitations of any theoretical perspective, our framework for community engagement does not claim to address all the complexities of project sustainability. Three specific limitations should be taken into consideration when applying the reciprocity framework in practice. First, we emphasized the importance of the ‘micro’ dimension of extractive projects by focusing on the implications for local communities. Building on the literature, our premise is that local communities are critical stakeholders in mining projects because of the direct impacts they suffer, often in very isolated and already underdeveloped regions. A focus on the ‘micro’ dimension of extractive projects should not, however, dismiss discussion of the broader impacts of extractive industries on society at large. These micro-macro dynamics are at the heart of discussions on sustainable development where trade-offs exist when balancing local, national, and global needs. Furthermore, they are relevant in determining whether a project (and its related community development efforts) receives support or opposition, and from which constituents. A recent example is the keystone XL pipeline development project that has suffered from considerable delays and setbacks, in large part due to varying justifications for and against the project at both the local and national levels (e.g. environmental damages to local communities vs. broader economic benefits, economic benefits to local communities vs. broader environmental consequences). Second, our framework for community engagement implicitly considers local communities as homogenous groups in which members are at a consensus on what constitutes a need. The reality is more complex in light of the often-heterogeneous composition of communities that can result in competing beliefs regarding the most pressing needs of the community and whether an extractive project should be approved based on the local needs it addresses. The literature indicates that socio-political dynamics of the community are an important variable in the implementation of the reciprocity framework insofar as there is no such thing as a singular vision of sustainable development. For example, it has been shown empirically that the most powerful members of a community are most able to assert their interests, often to the detriment of the most marginalized (Guijt & Shah, 1998). Practitioners implementing the reciprocity framework should be wary that heterogeneity within a community may require value judgments in weighing the needs of one group against the other, which would likely be met with contention. Lastly, our discussion of the fostering of capabilities of local communities raises some important but unanswered questions regarding the challenges of balancing the impacts and benefits of the individual vs. the collective. Even within local communities, extractive projects can generate varying impacts across individuals, an issue that has been addressed by compensation schemes that consider individual-level impacts. This practice, however, raises concerns of equity in many local communities where social cohesion has suffered due to compensation across individuals within the same community varying considerably.

The allocation of disbursements and benefits across individuals, whether uniform or not, is thus a practical consideration that project promoters must consider that the reciprocity framework’s community level of analysis does not directly account for.

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